

3. Why was it used in the wrong way? The engineer who used it didn't know how to use it properly.
4. Why didn't he know? Because he was never trained.
5. Why wasn't he trained? Because his manager doesn't believe in training new engineers because he and his team are "too busy."

What began as a purely technical fault is revealed quickly to be a very human managerial issue.

Make a Proportional Investment

Here's how to use Five Whys analysis to build an adaptive organization: consistently make a proportional investment at each of the five levels of the hierarchy. In other words, the investment should be smaller when the symptom is minor and larger when the symptom is more painful. We don't make large investments in prevention unless we're coping with large problems.

In the example above, the answer is to fix the server, change the subsystem to make it less error-prone, educate the engineer, and, yes, have a conversation with the engineer's manager.

This latter piece, the conversation with the manager, is always hard, especially in a startup. When I was a startup manager, if you told me I needed to invest in training my people, I would have told you it was a waste of time. There were always too many other things to do. I'd probably have said something sarcastic like "Sure, I'd be happy to do that—if you can spare my time for the eight weeks it'll take to set up." That's manager-speak for "No way in hell."

That's why the proportional investment approach is so important. If the outage is a minor glitch, it's essential that we make only a minor investment in fixing it. Let's do the first hour of the eight-week plan. That may not sound like much, but it's a start. If the problem recurs, asking the Five Whys will require that we continue to make progress on it. If the problem does not occur again, an hour isn't a big loss.